

Perhaps most disturbingly, Sherman's appetite for war was growing with each step up the career ladder; "a manic elation," as critic Edmund Wilson observed, "that compensated for the earlier demoralization." The wake of burning wreckage that marked his passage from Atlanta, Georgia, to Columbia, South Carolina, over a period of three months had proved Sherman to be a formidable foe. Then, in an about-face, he was all conciliation. In April 1865, Sherman offered Joseph E. Johnston, who was negotiating the surrender of the Confederacy's remaining armies, terms so generous that an enraged secretary of war, Edwin M. Stanton, tried relieving him of command.

Sherman remained in uniform after the Civil War, but opposed the Republicans' harsh measures under Reconstruction. That didn't stop him from succeeding Grant—elected the Republican president in 1869—as the Commanding General of the Army. He held the post for the next 15 years, when the Indian Wars in the West approached their tragic culmination. Despite being named for an American Indian warrior, both Sherman and his successor, Philip Sheridan, shared the hostility toward American Indians felt by the majority of Regular Army officers during the 19th century.